me. I had learned my final lesson in how to survive Australia: build your hives a good few feet off the ground as you travel north.

On the run, we learned a little bushcraft. We learned how to get by on very little money and not enough normality. Being unsettled was our normality and we became good at it. There was an Australian traveller called Nat Buchanan (‘Old Bluey’), who travelled light and had a gift for exploring Australia and making something of his independence. A book written by his great-granddaughter Bobbie Buchanan, *In the Tracks of Old Bluey*, reveals a man who knew Queensland, a man who knew how to co-exist with animals and humans, a man whose temperament led him to show courage when faced with life’s obstacles. Buchanan was a nomad of Irish stock, just like us, and, also like us, he passed his habits on to his children. Difference is, I suppose, that while Old Bluey was chasing nature and finding himself, we were being chased by a force of nature we could barely contend with, and getting lost. Nat was a pioneer, the first man, as Bobbie wrote, ‘to cross the Barkly Tablelands from east to west and first to take a large herd of breeding cattle from Queensland to the Top End of the Northern Territory’. Nat died in 1901, more than eighty years before my mother, my brother and I were driving as fugitives past the Tanami Desert. ‘Nat was a colourful, if enigmatic character,’ his relative’s book says, ‘whose story is quite remarkable and needs no exaggeration.’

My mother changed her name. We worked out that Leif must have had contacts within the social security administration – that was how The Family is thought to have worked – so it seemed best to change the names that would be held inside the government computer system. But he was quite a gifted talker and would get friends to supply him with information about our whereabouts and he would always catch up. It was a private investigator who eventually came and told us about his close relationship with the Anne Hamilton-Byrne cult. We were living in Fern Tree Gully, and I was now sixteen years old. We’d come to the end of the road. Also, I was feeling almost a man myself and was ready to front-up to him. Masculinity and its discontents could be addressed here, but let’s just say I knew I could waste him and he appeared to know it, too. He was lurking round the bounds of the house and I walked over and told him to fuck off. It was the first and the last time, and something in the way I said it ensured that we would never see him again. He would push, for a time, for access to my brother, but his history spoke against him and he was gone.